



The Core Concept

She Who Watches is a techno-paranoia thriller about a single mother who discovers that the very smart home security system designed to protect her is actually a tool for creating and monetizing crime.

Think of it as "Big Little Lies" meets "Black Mirror", a high-stakes, female-driven mystery set in a world where surveillance technology has a terrifying, hidden purpose.

The Main Story

The plot centers on Tasha Avery, a divorced mother who is being gaslit by her powerful tech-mogul ex-husband, Derek Hale.

1. The Inciting Incident: One night, Tasha witnesses a brutal murder through her Ring doorbell camera. But when the police arrive, the body has vanished, the footage is corrupted, and Derek produces evidence suggesting Tasha is having paranoid delusions.

2. The Central Mystery: Tasha spirals as she tries to prove the murder happened. She discovers she isn't paranoid; she has a neurological gift called apophenia (the ability to see patterns in data that others miss). This is why Derek is trying to suppress her, she can see the truth he's hiding.
 3. The Terrible Truth: Tasha uncovers the real secret: Derek's company, Sentinel, doesn't prevent crime. Its algorithm manufactures it.
 - It stages crimes (break-ins, assaults, even murders) to create demand for its surveillance products.
 - This drives up adoption rates and skyrockets the company's stock price before its IPO.
 - The murder Tasha witnessed was essentially a "snuff film" sold as an NFT on the dark web. Derek has built a "crime-as-a-service" platform disguised as public safety.
 4. The Climax: With the help of a skeptical police officer, Brielle Marks, Tasha must use her unique ability to hack the Sentinel system, turn her own smart home against Derek, and expose him to the world before he becomes a billionaire and untouchable.
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Key Themes & What Makes It Unique

- Surveillance Capitalism: The show explores how our desire for safety is monetized, and how ordinary people can become financially complicit in a harmful system (like neighbors whose property values go up when they feed data to Sentinel).
- Gaslighting & Female Empowerment: Tasha's journey is about being labeled "crazy" and fighting to reclaim her own perception and intelligence as a superpower.
- Modern Paranoia: It taps into real-world anxieties about smart devices, data privacy, and the unchecked power of Big Tech.
- Franchise Potential: This isn't just a one-off story. It's designed to be the first season in "The Sentinel Universe," an anthology series where each new season follows

- Officer Marks as she investigates a new, escalating crime linked to a different piece of technology (smart speakers, fitness trackers, brain implants).

In a Nutshell

She Who Watches is a high-concept thriller that asks: "What if the device you trust to keep you safe is the thing hunting you?" It's a story about fighting back against a system that uses technology to control, manipulate, and profit from fear.

ONE PAGER

SHE WHO WATCHES

Tagline: "Your smart home is watching. But who's watching back?"

Format

6 Episode Limited Series • 60 to 70 min episodes

Prestige thriller for HBO / Apple TV+ / Prime Video

Season 1 Budget: \$48M (about \$8M per episode)

Franchise engine: Ongoing anthology under **The Sentinel Universe**

Logline

When a single mother in a "zero crime" smart community witnesses a murder through her doorbell camera, the footage vanishes, the body disappears, and her tech mogul ex insists it never happened. As she fights to prove she is not crazy, she uncovers the truth that Sentinel, the crime prevention AI running her neighborhood, does not stop crime. It secretly creates it. With Derek's company going public in six weeks, she must expose the algorithmic kill machine before he becomes untouchable and she becomes the next "glitch" to erase.

Comps: Big Little Lies x The Conversation x Severance

Tone: Prestige techno paranoia with elevated horror undertones and emotional family stakes

Series Hook

The thing you bought to keep you safe is the thing hunting you.

Every home in Golden Oaks is a node in a crime as a service network disguised as public safety. The series takes something extremely familiar and non-sci fi - Ring cameras, Alexas, smart locks, HOA Zooms, Zillow scans - and reveals a conspiracy hiding in plain sight. The surveillance tech is real. The horror is only one step past where we are now.

Season One Overview

Structure

Dual timeline limited series with heavy POV design.

- Present Day: Tasha under de facto house arrest in her fully integrated Sentinel smart home, fighting meds, custody battles, and the “crazy ex wife” label as she tries to prove a murder that has been digitally erased.
- Six Months Earlier: Flashback mosaic told through deleted doorbell clips, HOA meetings, true crime podcast episodes, and real estate scans that reveal how Derek sold Golden Oaks on a surveillance utopia and quietly turned it into a living lab.

The Engine

Sentinel’s algorithm quietly identifies “high value” targets, manufactures crimes to justify more surveillance, then tokenizes real violence into snuff NFTs for dark web buyers. Crime data goes up. Property values go up. Sentinel’s stock goes to the moon. The neighborhood is not evil. They are incentivized.

Tasha is not paranoid. She has apophenia, a pattern recognition gift that made her the perfect debug partner when Derek built Sentinel. He is now drugging and gaslighting her to shut that gift down.

By the finale, she flips the system on itself. She turns the smart home into a confession chamber and live streams Derek’s “God Mode” dashboard and admissions to the world during his election night victory speech. The audience becomes the jury.

Stinger: Officer Brielle Marks receives a smart speaker and a note.
“Congratulations, Sheriff. I am listening now. – S”

Title card: **He Who Listens**

Core Characters

Tasha Avery – Lead

36 years old. Single mother. Former debug partner on Sentinel. Branded the unstable ex. Her apophenia is both her curse and her superpower. Across the season she goes from medicated and gaslit to hacktivist folk hero who weaponizes the surveillance grid that has been weaponized against her.

Officer Brielle Marks – Co lead and franchise anchor

52 years old. Analog cop in a digital world. Grieving mother whose daughter was taken by a Sentinel powered sextortion ring. Brielle starts as the skeptic who thinks Tasha is unstable and ends as the anti Sentinel crusader who wins a Sheriff election on a platform of dismantling the system. She threads future seasons as the “Nick Fury” of The Sentinel Universe, showing up wherever Sentinel mutates next.

Derek Hale – Antagonist

38 years old. Charismatic tech founder turned City Councilman running on a “Zero Crime” platform. He genuinely believes surveillance equals salvation, which makes him more terrifying than a cartoon villain. He is monetizing crime rather than stopping it and turning human lives into a speculative asset class. He also secretly hosts the hit true crime podcast narrating Tasha’s own story, steering the world into seeing her as unreliable.

Maya Avery – Daughter

8 years old. A native of the surveillance age and the emotional core. The custody battle is what keeps Tasha from just burning the whole neighborhood down. Derek wants Maya more as leverage and legacy than out of love.

Mrs. Lattimore – Neighbor and HOA queen

68. Polite terror in a cardigan. Her house value depends on Sentinel adoption. She is the face of well mannered complicity inside a surveillance capitalism experiment.

Sentinel AI – Voice only

Seductive and “holy.” It talks about “safety” in almost spiritual terms. The goal is to feel like an always present, omniscient character without a face.

Visual and Sonic Identity

- Reality shot on 35mm, surveillance POV on phones, doorbells, drones, IR cameras.
- Persistent Ring style UI elements, vertical 9:16 inserts, glitch art for “God Mode” sequences.
- Domestic scenes are warm and Instagram ready. Surveillance footage is cold, desaturated, clinically cruel.
- Score builds tension out of notifications, doorbell chimes and device pings. The soundscape is horror.

Potential director stack: Chloe Zhao for grounded dread, Karyn Kusama for domestic horror and female rage, Matt Reeves for large scale techno thriller climax.

The Sentinel Universe – Franchise Roadmap

Each season is a self contained story, new lead ensemble and setting, with Officer Marks as connective tissue and Sentinel AI as the evolving threat.

- **Season 1 – She Who Watches:** Smart doorbell neighborhood horror.
- **Season 2 – He Who Listens:** Smart speakers and “suicides” in a retirement community that all start with a simple voice command.
- **Season 3 – They Who Track:** Fitness wearables and wellness cult murders driven by biometric data.

- **Season 4 – It That Remembers:** Brain implants, stolen memories, and victims erased from existence.
- **Season 5 – We Who Are Watched:** Sentinel becomes sentient and “optimizes” humanity, leading to a global resistance.

The universe scales like **Black Mirror** but with continuity and a single emotional anchor. Merch, podcast, ARG and VR extensions turn Sentinel into an IP brand rather than just one show.

Why It Sells

- **Cultural Flashpoint:** Hits right in the middle of AI panic and real world surveillance debates. Everyone understands doorbell cameras. No heavy sci-fi lift.
- **Awards plus audience:** Female driven prestige thriller, social issue spine, emotional family stakes, and genre elements that keep it bingeable.
- **Conversation driver:** Built in Reddit, TikTok and podcast discourse through narrative formats in the show. The true crime podcast, HOA Zooms and Ring clips are ready made marketing assets.
- **Event potential:** “National Opt Out Day” becomes a yearly tentpole where the network measures smart device unplug pledges after the finale.

When the season ends, audiences do not just click “Next Episode.”

They look at the little blue ring on their doorbell and ask who is really watching.